

What Came Up the Riser

by Douglass Burley Johnson

My hands were on a chain binder, cranking down the last stack of drill pipe on the pipe rack, when the evacuation helicopter lifted off the pad without us.

I was nineteen. It was Saturday, the seventh of September, 1974, and I was on my first hitch as a roustabout on a jackup drilling rig called the Ellen Kay, standing on three steel legs in ninety feet of water seventy miles south of Terrebonne Bay. Hurricane Carmen was out in the Gulf turning toward Louisiana, and the company had been flying men to the beach since morning. Four of us were supposed to go out on the last trip. The pilot came in low with the wind already pushing his tail sideways, looked at the gusts tearing spray off the swells, and waved us off through the bubble. Then he leaned that Bell away toward Houma and was gone into the gray, and the four of us stood on the deck in our slickers with the rain starting to come in flat.

"He'll come back," I said.

"He won't," said Hollis Kane. Hollis was the toolpusher, which meant he was the boss of the whole rig, and he was a long, sour, sun-cured man from Beaumont who had never once that I knew of said good morning. "Not in this. We ride it."

Dewey Lanclos, the driller, spat over the rail and said a word in French that my grandmother used to slap us for. Ellis Ware, the cook, did not say anything at all. He looked out at the weather for a while with his hands in the pockets of his white apron, and then he turned around and went back inside to the galley, and a minute later I heard him start singing.

That was Ellis. He was a big, gray-headed Black man from Morgan City, fifty-eight years old, and he had been cooking offshore since before there was much offshore to cook on. He kept a fat, swollen Bible on the shelf by the coffee urn with a rubber band around it to hold the loose pages in, and he sang while he cooked, old church songs in a deep voice that came up through the deck plates like a diesel idling. The men mostly let him. Hollis told him to hush about once a day. I had made fun of him behind his back my first week, the way a nineteen-year-old does, doing his voice for Dewey in the bunkroom. Ellis had heard me through the wall, and the next morning he put an extra pork chop on my plate and never said a word about it, and I had been ashamed of myself every breakfast since.

What he was singing that afternoon was an old one. "Will your anchor hold in the storms of life," he sang, slow, over the bang of pots, "when the clouds unfold their wings of strife."

"Tell him to sing a different song," Dewey said.

"You tell him," Hollis said.

Nobody told him.

By dark the Ellen Kay was taking a beating. A jackup rig stands through a storm on its legs instead of floating. Our hull sat up on those three legs sixty feet above the water, and the

legs went down into the Gulf and into the mud below it, and the whole idea was that the waves would pass underneath us and slap the legs and keep going. All that night they did not keep going quietly. They came in black and enormous out of the south and hit the legs with a sound like a train hitting a culvert, and the hull shook, and every loose thing on board walked across the floor. Rain came sideways so hard it stung through a slicker. The wind screamed in the derrick over our heads, and the derrick swayed, and you could watch the swaying in the way the coffee leaned in Ellis's cups.

We had a well under us. That was the other thing. We had drilled eleven thousand feet down and set steel casing and capped it, and before the evacuation started Hollis had shut it in, which means he had closed the big valves on the blowout preventer so no gas or oil could come up. The blowout preventer was a stack of valves as tall as a two-story house that sat on top of the well, under the rig floor, down on a lower level everybody called the cellar deck. From the bottom of that stack a long steel pipe ran down through the ninety feet of water into the mud. The men called that pipe the riser. Everything that came up from the well came up the riser and through the stack, and the stack was what stood between four men on a rig and eleven thousand feet of gas pressure.

At about midnight the knocking started.

Dewey heard it first. He was sitting in the driller's shack on the rig floor, which everyone called the doghouse, watching the gauges with his boots up, and Hollis and I were in there with him drinking Ellis's coffee because it was the only room on the rig floor with a window you could see the derrick from. Under the scream of the wind and the boom of the waves on the legs, there came a knock. It came from down under the floor. Then another one. They came about two

seconds apart, steady, heavy, a hollow iron knock that came up through our boot soles as much as through our ears.

"That's the riser," Dewey said, and he put his boots down.

"Wave slap," Hollis said.

"Waves don't count, Hollis."

Waves don't. The knocks kept coming, one every two seconds, and every knock was a little louder than the one before it, and a little higher, the way footsteps sound on a stairway when a man is coming up toward you.

Hollis got up and took the big six-cell flashlight off the hook and went out the doghouse door into the storm, and Dewey went after him, and I went after Dewey because I was nineteen and too scared to stay in that shack alone. The wind tried to take me off the rig floor in the first step. I got hold of the handrail and went hand over hand behind Dewey to the stairs, and we climbed down the stairs into the cellar deck with the rain pouring through the grating over our heads and the whole steel world groaning around us.

The blowout preventer stood in the middle of the cellar deck like a red iron tower, all bolts and flanges and hydraulic hoses, and under it there was a round hole in the deck plate where the riser came up out of the dark. Hollis put the flashlight beam straight down the hole along the pipe.

I have told this a hundred times since, and I have never once told it right.

Coming up the outside of the riser out of the black water was a living thing as thick through the body as a fifty-five-gallon drum. It was wrapped around the pipe the way a vine wraps a fence post, coil over coil, and it was climbing. Its skin was gray and wet and plated in big flat scales the size of hubcaps, and each scale had a dull shine to it like old pewter in the

flashlight. Along its back ran a ragged mane of weed and torn fishing net. Every time it pulled its body up another coil, the scales knocked against the steel, and that was the sound we had heard in the doghouse. Then its head came up into the light. It was long and narrow like the skull of a horse, with no lips over its teeth, and its eyes threw the flashlight back at us the way a deer's eyes throw back headlights, flat and yellow and empty.

Dewey said, "Mother of God," and sat down on the wet deck plate.

Hollis stood where he was with the flashlight beam held dead steady, and I could hear him breathing through his nose.

The thing took hold of the bottom of the blowout preventer with the front of its body and squeezed.

Every bolt in that stack groaned at once. A hydraulic hose tore loose and whipped across the cellar deck, spraying red fluid, and Hollis ducked and the hose went by over his head. Up on the stack a gauge needle I could see in the edge of the flashlight jumped and started to climb. I did not know much yet, but I knew what that needle meant. That thing was squeezing the stack hard enough to unseat the rams, which are the big steel jaws inside the preventer that close off the well, and if those rams let go, the gas would come up the casing under eleven thousand feet of pressure and hit the rig floor and find a spark, and that would be the end of the Ellen Kay and everybody on her.

"Back up the stairs," Hollis said. "Now."

We went. In the doghouse Hollis grabbed the control panel for the preventer and slammed the levers that should have forced the rams shut tighter, and the panel lights flickered and the pressure on the hydraulic gauge fell to zero. The hose that had torn loose was the line to the rams.

"Hand wheels," Dewey said. He was white and soaking wet. "Lock 'em by hand."

Every set of rams on a stack like ours had a big iron hand wheel on each side, like a steering wheel on an old truck, that you could crank to screw the rams shut and lock them there if the hydraulics ever quit. It took about sixty turns a wheel. There were two wheels on the set of rams that mattered. They were down on the cellar deck, at the stack, a man's arm length from that thing's coils.

Hollis looked at the gauge. He looked at Dewey. Then he looked at me, because I was the youngest and the skinniest and the only one who would fit between the stack and the bracing on the far side, and I knew before he opened his mouth what he was going to say.

"Guidry," he said. "I'll hold the light. Dewey's on the choke to bleed off what he can. You turn the wheels."

I tried to answer him and my mouth would not work.

Ellis Ware was standing in the doghouse door. I do not know how long he had been there. He had his slicker on over his apron, and he had the rubber band off his Bible and the Bible inside his slicker against his chest.

"I'm going with the boy," Ellis said.

"You're the cook," Hollis said.

"Yes sir," Ellis said. "I'm going with the boy."

Then he did a thing I had never seen anybody do on a rig. He walked over to the squawk box on the doghouse wall, the intercom that ran to speakers all over the Ellen Kay, and he keyed it and held the button down and taped it there with a strip of electrical tape off Dewey's console, so every speaker on the rig would carry whatever came out of that doghouse. Then he turned to Dewey.

"Sing," Ellis said. "You know the anchor song. You've been complaining about it for two years. Sing it into that box and don't you stop."

And Dewey Lanclos, who swore in two languages and had not been inside a church since his wedding, opened his mouth and sang. He sang it bad and too fast, but he sang it, and it came out of every speaker on the Ellen Kay over the wind. "We have an anchor that keeps the soul steadfast and sure while the billows roll."

Ellis put his big hand on the back of my neck and walked me out into the storm.

Going down those stairs the second time is the bravest thing I have ever done, and I did it with a cook's hand on my neck. The cellar deck was half underwater by then. Every big wave came up through the hole around the riser and through the open sides and broke across the plates in a white sheet, and we waded through it to the knees. Hollis came down behind us with the flashlight. The thing had wrapped two more coils around the bottom of the stack. Its head was up on the far side now, swaying at about the height of my chest, and when the light hit it the yellow eyes turned toward us.

The speaker on the bracing over our heads was full of Dewey singing.

The head went back, away from the speaker, the way a dog backs off from a hot stove.

"There," Ellis said. "Go on, Remy. Turn."

I squeezed in between the stack and the bracing on my side and found the first hand wheel with both hands. It was cold iron and wet and as big around as I could reach. I turned it, and it fought me. With my boot against the bracing I turned it again, and it moved a quarter turn, and I kept going, one, two, three. I counted out loud because if I did not count I was going to scream. A wave came up through the deck and hit me in the back and went over my head, and I held on to the wheel and came up spitting salt and kept turning. Eleven. Twelve.

Ellis stood out in the open in the flashlight beam, in water to his knees, between me and that head. Ellis had the Bible out of his slicker, and he held it up closed in his left hand, the way a flagman holds up a flag, and he talked to the thing in an ordinary voice, the same voice he used to tell us supper was on.

"I know what you are," Ellis said. "You came up out of the deep the way your kind always do. You don't scare me. I serve the One who walked on your water. He told the sea to be still, and it was still. In the name of Jesus Christ, you be still."

The thing stopped.

Its head held still at the height of my chest, and its coils held still around the stack, and the groaning in the bolts stopped. On the speaker Dewey kept singing. The wind did not stop and the waves did not stop, but that living thing on the riser held as still as a photograph, and its yellow eyes stayed on Ellis.

I finished the first wheel at sixty-one turns, and through the iron I could tell the rams had locked. Then I crawled under the bracing on my belly in the water to the other side of the stack, to the second wheel, and that put me so close to the thing's body that I could smell it. It smelled like the bottom of a bait well. I put my hands on the second wheel and started to turn.

At twenty-six turns the big wave came.

This one was bigger than the others. Up through the deck it came with a roar and lifted all of us, and it tore the flashlight out of Hollis's hand and put it out, and for one second there was only black and salt water and Dewey singing on the speaker, and then the deck lights flickered back on. When the water ran off, Ellis was down. The wave had knocked him off his feet and carried him across the plates, and he had fetched up against the base of the stack right in the

thing's coils. One loop of it had closed over his legs. Ellis had his arms around a flange and his face up out of the water, and the Bible was gone.

The head came down toward him.

"Turn the wheel, Remy," Ellis said. He said it calm. "Turn the wheel."

I did. God help me, I turned the wheel, because the gauge was still climbing and if I let go we were all dead, Ellis too. My hands were bleeding where the iron rim had worn through the skin. And while my hands turned it, I yelled. I had not prayed since my grandmother's funeral. I did not know any words but the ones I had just heard a cook say, and I knew while I yelled them that they were only worth the breath if the Man they named was who Ellis said He was. I yelled them at that thing with my whole chest.

"In the name of Jesus Christ," I yelled, "let him go!"

It let go.

The coil came off Ellis's legs like a rope coming off a cleat. The head pulled back and away. And then the whole gray length of it unwound off the stack and slid down through the hole around the riser into the black water, coil after coil after coil, knocking on the steel all the way down, quieter and quieter, until the hole held only the waves.

I finished the second wheel at fifty-nine turns. The rams locked. Up in the doghouse, Dewey watched the gauge needle stop and fall back, and he quit singing just long enough to whoop over the squawk box, and then he started the song again from the top.

Hollis and I dragged Ellis up the stairs. His left leg was bruised black from the knee to the ankle for a month, but it was not broken.

When we got Ellis into the doghouse and put him in Dewey's chair, the wind stopped.

All at once it stopped, with no tapering at all, and the rain quit with it, and the scream in the derrick went quiet. The waves kept rolling under us, big and slow, but the slap on the legs softened into a long easy wash. I went to the doghouse window and looked up, and over the top of the derrick there were stars.

"Eye of the storm," Hollis said. "That's the eye coming over."

"Could be," said Ellis.

The wind came back about forty minutes later, from the other direction, and blew until noon, but no living thing came up the riser again. A Coast Guard helicopter took us off on Monday. A week later, in the Houma paper, I saw a map of Carmen's track. The eye had come ashore near the mouth of the Atchafalaya, south of Morgan City, around one in the morning. It had passed more than sixty miles west of the Ellen Kay. We had never been in the eye. I cut that map out and I still have it.

On Monday morning, waiting for the helicopter, Hollis Kane sat down across from Ellis in the galley. Ellis had his leg up on a chair and a cup of coffee in his hand, and Hollis had not slept, and neither had I. Hollis turned his cup around on the table a few times. Then he asked it.

"Who were you talking to down there?"

"Same man the disciples asked about," Ellis said, "the night He told the wind to hush. They said, who is this, that even the wind and the sea obey Him."

"And who is He?"

Ellis drank his coffee. "That's the question, Mr. Kane," he said. "Every man has to answer it for himself. I answered it a long time ago. The boy answered it last night." He set the cup down. "Your turn's coming."

Hollis did not say anything to that. He got up and went out on deck to wait for the helicopter by himself.

I am seventy-one years old now and I live in Houma. I worked offshore forty-one more years after that hitch and made it to toolpusher myself, and I never saw that thing again, and I never once told the story to a company man. The Ellen Kay was cut up for scrap in 1991. Ellis Ware passed in 1983, and I sang the anchor song at his funeral in Morgan City, bad and too fast, the way Dewey did. Dewey called me every September on the seventh until he died in 2019.

I have one scale. I found it the Monday after the storm, jammed in the spokes of the second hand wheel, gray and flat and as big as a hubcap. It sits on my mantel. In 1980 I took it to a man at LSU who studied fish, and he turned it over a long time under his lamp and said "Gar. Very big gar," and handed it back to me without looking me in the face.

Hollis Kane died in 2002. I went to the service in Beaumont and sat in the back. Nobody there could tell me what he answered. I have thought about him every hurricane season since, sitting in that galley turning his cup, with a cook across the table asking him the only question that ever mattered on that rig or any other.

Who is this, that even the wind and the sea obey Him?

I know what I answered, down in the water with my hands on that wheel. I still sing it every hitch I can, bad and too fast. Our anchor held.

END